



This 18th-century painting shows Mark Antony fleeing from the battle scene at Actium in 31 BCE. Many of his supporters defected to Octavian's side as a result.



Augustus built a new Forum at Rome, with an imposing new temple to Mars.

IN ROME, THE PERIOD AFTER THE ASSASSINATION of Julius Caesar saw rising tensions between **Mark Antony** and **Octavian**, whom many viewed as Caesar's rightful heir. The two almost came to blows early in 43 BCE, when Octavian marched to raise the **siege of Mutina** (Modena, Italy), where Mark Antony was besieging Decimus Brutus, one of Caesar's assassins. Mark Antony was forced to retreat to Gaul. When the Senate voted to transfer Octavian's legions to Decimus Brutus, Octavian realized he was being sidelined and formed a three-way alliance with Mark Antony and **Marcus Lepidus**, the governor of Transalpine Gaul. This became the **Second Triumvirate**.

The Triumvirate conducted a war against **Cassius and Marcus Brutus**, two more of Caesar's assassins, who had seized much of the territory in the east.

In 42 BCE, Mark Antony and Octavian defeated

10 THE NUMBER OF YEARS THE SECOND TRIUMVIRATE RULED ROME

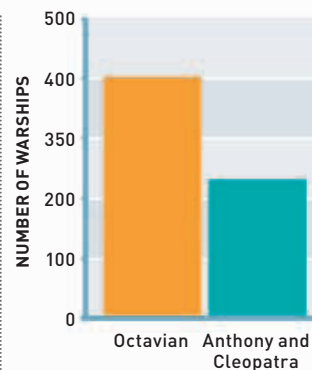
them at **Philippi**, in northern Greece, after which Cassius committed suicide. Three weeks later, they destroyed the remnants of Marcus Brutus's army. Mark Antony stayed in the east until 40 BCE, when he returned to Italy to try to undermine the **growing power of Octavian**. Their two armies refused to fight, and a de facto **division of the Roman world** was

agreed, with Mark Antony ruling the east and Octavian governing the west; Lepidus had to make do with Africa. The **Triumvirate was renewed** in 38 BCE for a further five years, but it was clear that conflict between Octavian and Mark Antony could not long be postponed.

However, Mark Antony was occupied with a **war against the Parthians**, who were allied with remnants of Cassius's army and **attacked Syria** in 39 BCE. In 36 BCE, Mark Antony **invaded Parthia** itself—ostensibly to recover the legionary eagles captured by the Parthians at the **Battle of Carrhae** (see 53 BCE)—and advanced to the capital Phraata, but he did not have

Suicide of Cleopatra

This 19th-century painting depicts the death of Cleopatra, who killed herself to avoid being captured by Octavian and taken to Rome.



Battle of Actium

Octavian's fleet outnumbered that of Mark Antony and Cleopatra, with smaller more manoeuvrable ships, and fresher, better trained crews.

sufficient resources to besiege it.

In 33 BCE, the **Triumvirate expired** and Octavian had the Senate declare Mark Antony a **public enemy**. The latter had lost popularity through his relationship with **Cleopatra**, the Egyptian queen, and Octavian quickly rallied public opinion to himself. A fleet was rapidly assembled, and this destroyed Mark Antony's naval force at **Actium**, off western Greece, in September 31 BCE. Mark Antony's land army then **defected** to Octavian, and Antony and Cleopatra **fled to Greece**, where Octavian caught up with them in the summer of 30 BCE. The Roman warlord and the Egyptian queen both **committed suicide**, and Egypt was annexed to the Roman empire. **Octavian** was now the **unchallenged master** of the whole Roman world.

HAVING DEFEATED HIS ENEMIES, **Octavian** did not take on the title of dictator, as Julius Caesar had. He instead ruled informally as the **princeps**—the **first man of the state**. Having acquired control of Antony's legions, he now had an army of about 500,000 men. He disbanded more than half of these, retaining 28 legions (about 150,000 soldiers), settling the remainder in colonies in Italy and abroad. In 27 BCE, Octavian gave up all his powers, ostensibly **restoring the Republic**. The Senate responded by granting him personal control of Egypt, Gaul, Germany, Spain, and Syria. He was also given the title "**Augustus**" and, cementing his position further, he was consul each year from 27 to 23 BCE. Over time, the Senate voted Augustus **further powers**, including that of *imperium maius* in 23 BCE, which gave him supreme authority in the provinces he had not previously governed, and the permanent powers of a **tribune of the plebs** in 23 BCE. Although the Senate was, in theory, the supreme authority in Rome, in practice no one could match Augustus's power, and he is seen as the **first Roman emperor**.

North Africa had been a center of strong resistance to both Julius Caesar and Augustus, who settled many army veterans there. In 25 BCE, Augustus gave Mauretania (western North Africa) to **Juba II of Numidia**. Juba, whose wife was the daughter of Mark Antony and Cleopatra, proved a reliable **Roman ally**. Augustus still sent a legion to garrison North Africa, where it stayed for over 300 years.

